



BALL PYTHON · PYTHON REGIUS

Keep your ball python the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: enclosure and heat, the humidity range that decides everything, feeding refusals, health triage, and the routines that keep a ball python thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every temperature in °F and °C, with a labeled enclosure diagram
- ✓ A prey chart, thawing method, and the seven reasons a ball python stops eating
- ✓ Six health pages, from respiratory infection to reading shed and stool
- ✓ Printable emergency card, pet-sitter sheet, owner log, and a 12-month planner

34 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

Version 2.2 · Sep 2026



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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 12 in order before buying anything. Enclosure material, heat control, and humidity are the three decisions that are expensive to redo, and they are the three most often chosen wrong. Get them right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 24 to buy once.

If your ball python is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Targets on page 22 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 16 if anything seems off. If the problem is that your snake won't eat, start on page 12 instead: refusal has seven common explanations in this species and only one of them is illness. If any heat source is running without a thermostat, fix that today, before anything else on this list.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 21: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 28: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 22: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 29: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 25: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 30: Equipment, Quarantine & Vet Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Ball python husbandry has moved a long way from the small-tub advice that dominated the hobby for years, and from the idea that a snake wants to feel cramped. This package reflects current enclosure-size, humidity, and enrichment standards, including the peer-reviewed housing research on page 13. Cross-checked against veterinary and herpetological sources (listed on page 34), not recycled forum advice. Every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile veterinarian experienced with ball pythons. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a professional call, not a page in this book. Find one before you need one and write the number on page 23.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Python regius</i> , also called the royal python
Adult size	Females 4 to 5 ft (120 to 150 cm), 1,200 to 1,800 g; males 3 to 3.5 ft (90 to 105 cm), 800 to 1,200 g
Captive lifespan	20 to 30 years, with well-documented individuals past 40
Native range	Grassland, open forest, and farmland across West and Central Africa
Diet type	Obligate carnivore. Whole frozen-thawed rodents, no supplementation needed
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm), about 8 sq ft of floor. Front-opening, PVC preferred
The one hard rule	Every heat source runs through a thermostat. No exceptions (page 7)
Sexual maturity	Males from about 8 to 12 months, females from about 2 to 3 years and by weight, not age
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate. Defensive as juveniles, notably mellow as settled adults
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN). Wild populations pressured by decades of collection for the pet trade

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$255 to \$845 for equipment, plus \$50 to \$150 for the first vet exam. The snake itself is \$40 to \$100 for a normal, \$50 to \$150 for a common morph.

Monthly ongoing

\$17 to \$47 for frozen-thawed rodents, substrate, electricity, and the annual exam averaged out. Roughly \$205 to \$565 a year.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$500 or more, and imaging or surgery pushes that higher. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but a 20 to 30 year animal will need a vet at some point. Set the money aside now rather than deciding in an emergency.

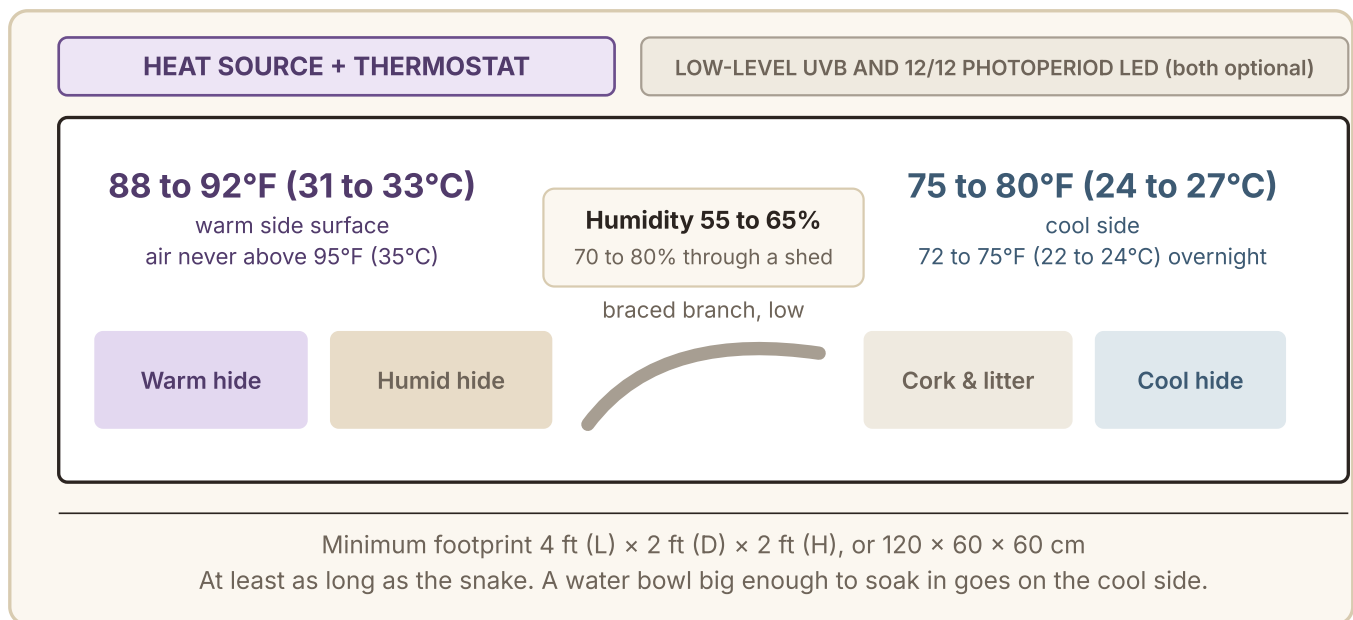
Fun facts worth knowing

- The name comes from the defensive pose, not the diet. A stressed ball python curls into a tight ball with its head tucked in the center, which is why a new snake that won't uncurl isn't being difficult. It just hasn't decided yet that hiding is unnecessary.
- They hunt with heat. Pits along the upper lip detect the body warmth of nearby prey, letting a ball python strike accurately in complete darkness.
- A brooding female generates her own heat. Through shivering thermogenesis she contracts her muscles repeatedly to keep the clutch warmer than the surrounding air, living off fat reserves for months while she does it.

Housing & enclosure

4×2×2 ft (48×24×24 in, 120×60×60 cm, roughly 120 gallons and about 8 square feet of floor) is the adult standard, and the enclosure should be at least as long as the snake. Scale down while the snake is small: hatchlings up to about 300 g do well in a 10-gallon or 20×11×13 in (50×28×33 cm) enclosure, and juveniles under 3 ft in a 36×18×18 in (90×45×45 cm) setup.

PVC holds humidity far better than glass, which matters more for this species than for almost any other beginner snake. A glass tank works if you cover three sides to cut evaporation and reflections. Whatever you use, it must lock or latch: ball pythons are patient, strong escape artists and a gap at a corner is all it takes. House one snake per enclosure.



NEVER

Run any heat source without a thermostat. An unregulated mat, tape, or panel is the direct cause of thermal burns and is a genuine fire hazard. Skip hot rocks entirely.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Clutter is not decoration for this species. Cork, plants, and leaf litter break up sightlines so the snake can be somewhere other than inside a hide without feeling exposed, which is what prevents the chronic stress that shows up as feeding refusal.
- Size hides snugly. A ball python feels secure when its body contacts the sides at several points, not when it is floating in an oversized box. A hide the snake rattles around in provides no security at all.
- Keep climbing structure low and braced at both ends. They are heavy-bodied and not agile, so stability matters far more than height.

Temperature, humidity & lighting

ZONE	TARGET (°F)	TARGET (°C)
Warm side surface, measured where the snake lies	88 to 92	31 to 33
Air temperature, anywhere in the enclosure	never above 95	never above 35
Cool side	75 to 80	24 to 27
Nighttime low	72 to 75	22 to 24
Humidity	55 to 65% baseline, raised to 70 to 80% from the moment the eyes go blue until the shed is complete.	

Measure the warm side at the surface the snake contacts, with an infrared thermometer, not the air above it. Read humidity with a digital hygrometer at substrate level; analog dials are inaccurate and a reading near the lid runs drier than what the snake experiences.

Humidity is what actually determines success

This is where most ball python problems start, and it runs wrong in both directions. Too dry gives you bad sheds, retained eye caps, and a higher respiratory infection risk. Too wet without real ventilation swings the other way toward scale rot and respiratory trouble from damp instead of cold. The species needs a stable middle, not a maximum, which is why the fix is almost never a spray bottle.

What holds it steady

A moisture-retaining substrate 3 to 4 in (7.5 to 10 cm) deep, a water bowl large enough to soak in, and a dedicated humid hide packed with damp sphagnum moss the snake can choose to use. PVC does most of this work for you; a screen-topped glass tank fights you the whole way and usually needs partial covering. Mist only to bring a reading back up, never on a schedule.

Lighting

UVB is genuinely optional here. Ball pythons have been kept successfully without it for decades, though a low-level gradient is reasonable enrichment if you want to provide it. What is not optional is a consistent 12 hours light and 12 hours dark on a timer, with no bright or colored bulbs at night. If the room falls below the nighttime range, use a ceramic heat emitter on its own thermostat rather than a light, so sleep is not disrupted.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Shed coming off in pieces rather than one length	Humidity too low, especially through the shed cycle
Soaking in the water bowl constantly	Too dry, too warm, or mites (page 18)
Condensation on the walls, substrate staying wet	Too humid or too little ventilation, scale rot risk (page 17)
Sitting on the cool side and refusing to move	Warm side running too hot; check the probe placement (page 7)

Thermostats, probes & heat sources

The thermostat is the safety device

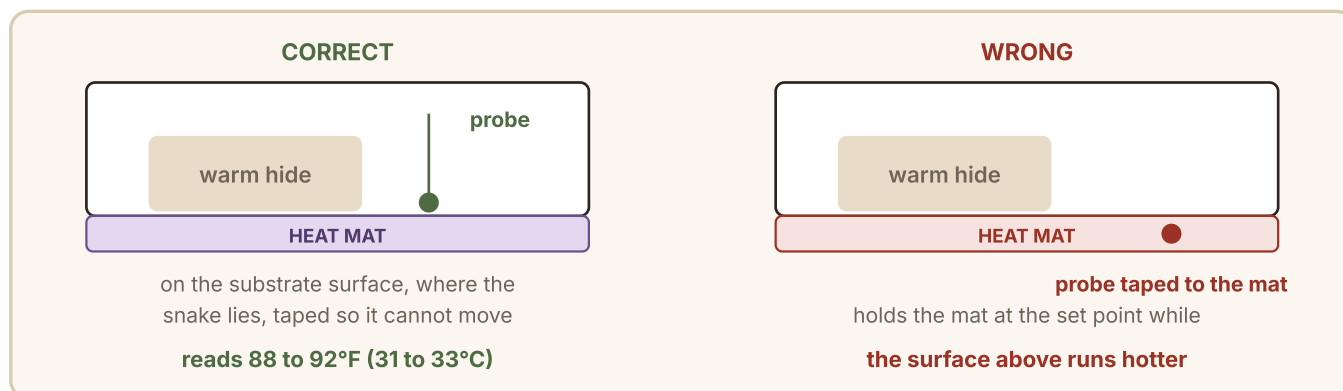
A thermostat sits between the heat source and your snake and stops a mat that reads 90°F (32°C) this morning from climbing on a warm afternoon. An unregulated under-tank heater can reach temperatures well above anything a snake can survive lying on, and a ball python will stay on a hot surface rather than move off it. This is the single most common preventable injury in the species, and the fix costs \$25 to \$100. Budget for the thermostat as part of the heat source, never as an upgrade to add later.

Use an **on/off or pulse thermostat** for an under-tank heater, heat tape, a ceramic heat emitter, or a radiant heat panel, which is the usual ball python setup. Use a **dimming thermostat** if you run an overhead halogen, which dislikes being switched on and off. Never put a UVB tube on a thermostat, and never run any heat source unregulated, not even briefly while you wait for a part. VCA puts any overhead source at least 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) above the highest spot the snake can reach, behind a screened top.

Where the probe goes

Probe placement is the part people get wrong after buying the right equipment. Put the probe where the snake actually lies: on the substrate surface at the warm end, or inside the warm hide, taped down so the snake cannot shift it. A probe taped to the heat mat itself reads the equipment rather than the animal and will hold the mat at your set point while the surface above it runs hotter. Verify with an infrared thermometer gun for the first week, then spot-check monthly.

Probe placement at a glance



Wattage is a starting guess, not a target. Let the thermostat and the infrared gun settle it, and re-check after any change of room, season, or substrate depth.

MEASURE, DON'T ASSUME

An infrared thermometer gun costs \$15 to \$30 and is the only way to know what the surface under your snake actually reads. Check the warm side, the cool side and both hides. Write the numbers on page 23 so a sitter or a vet can see them at a glance. Keep a second thermometer away from the thermostat's probe and read it daily: a thermostat stuck on, or a probe that has slipped, gives no other warning.

Substrate & furnishings

Substrate

Cypress mulch, or coconut coir and husk, 3 to 4 in (7.5 to 10 cm) deep. Both hold humidity at the level this species needs and let the snake burrow, which it will. Paper towel works fine temporarily, for quarantine or while treating a health issue, but it holds no humidity long term. Avoid aspen entirely: it molds at ball python humidity.

NEVER

Pine or cedar. Both contain aromatic oils toxic to reptiles. This is a hard exclusion, not a preference, and it applies to shavings, chips, and bedding sold under any brand name.

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Two snug hides, one warm side and one cool side, sized so the snake touches the sides
- ☐ Humid hide with damp sphagnum moss, kept year round
- ☐ Heavy, tip-resistant water bowl the snake can fully enter
- ☐ Cork bark tubes and flats for floor-level cover
- ☐ A branch braced at both ends, low enough that a fall isn't one
- ☐ Leaf litter or plants to break up open sightlines

Cleaning

Spot-clean waste and any soiled substrate daily, which takes under a minute and is most of the work. Scrub the water bowl weekly rather than topping it up, since a soaking snake will also defecate in it. Change the substrate fully every 4 to 8 weeks and wipe the enclosure down at the same time, using a reptile-safe disinfectant and rinsing thoroughly. Deep-clean and fully dry every hide and piece of decor at that point too: damp cork sitting on damp substrate is where scale rot starts (page 17).

A HIDE THE SNAKE RATTLES AROUND IN IS NOT A HIDE

The single most common furnishing mistake is buying hides that look comfortable to a human. A ball python feels secure when its body contacts the sides at several points, so a snug hide it has to squeeze into does more for its stress level than a large decorative cave ever will. Replace both hides as the snake grows out of them, and check the fit at every substrate change.

Handling & first days

How much, and how often

Don't handle a newly acquired ball python for the first one to two weeks, and don't start until it is eating on a normal schedule. Handling starts only once the snake has eaten successfully. After that, 2 to 3 sessions a week is a reasonable baseline, up to 3 to 5 for a snake that handles well, keeping each to 15 to 30 minutes. Overhandling causes real stress in this species and is a common cause of feeding refusal, so more is not automatically better.

Technique

Approach from the side rather than straight down from above, which reads as a predator strike. Support the body with both hands or along your forearms, lift from the middle rather than near the head or tail, and let the snake move at its own pace instead of restraining it. Keep sessions low over a bed or sofa rather than standing on a hard floor. Never grab or restrain the head.

- **Wait 48 to 72 hours after a meal before handling.** Handling too soon is one of the most common causes of regurgitation, and regurgitation damages the esophagus if it repeats.
- **Don't handle during a shed.** Cloudy or blue eyes mean the snake is functionally blind for a few days, which makes it more defensive and more likely to bite out of startlement rather than temperament.

Signs the session is over

Balling up tightly with the head tucked away, rapid or heavy breathing, hiding the head against your hand or arm, actively trying to move away, or musking, a foul-smelling release from the cloaca. A refused meal after a handling session counts too. None of these are aggression; put the snake back and shorten the next session. More on defensive behavior on page 20.

SALMONELLA

Healthy reptiles shed *Salmonella* without being ill, and one negative test clears nothing. It travels hands to face or food, so wash with soap after every contact with the snake, its enclosure or anything in it. Never clean gear in a kitchen sink, a bathroom sink or a bath people use; keep a plastic tub for it and nothing else. Do not kiss the snake or hold it near your face. Children under five, adults over 65, pregnant people and anyone immunocompromised are most at risk, and the CDC line for under-fives is not to handle reptiles or their environments at all.

First days in a new home

Set the enclosure up and running for 24 to 48 hours before the snake arrives, so the readings are already stable rather than settling around it. Then leave it alone: fresh water and spot-cleaning only for the first week, no handling and no rearranging, and resist the urge to check on it hourly. Offer the first meal at the end of that week, using the same prey type and size the seller was using. A refusal in week one is ordinary and is not a reason to change anything.

Diet & feeding by age

Ball pythons are obligate carnivores fed whole prey. Unlike most pets, the schedule gets slower as the animal gets bigger, not faster, and that slow metabolism is a feature of the species rather than a problem to solve.

AGE	WEIGHT	TYPICAL PREY	FEEDINGS	HOW MUCH
Hatchling, 0 to 6 months	under about 300 g	Hopper or small mouse	Every 5 to 7 days	One item, matched to body width
Juvenile, 6 to 18 months	300 to 800 g	Adult mouse to small rat	Every 7 to 10 days	One item, about 10% of body weight
Adult, 18 months and up	800 g and up	Medium rat	Every 10 to 14 days	One item, about 10% of body weight

Prey size is the whole rule

Feed prey roughly the same width as the widest part of the snake's body, or about 10% of its weight. Too large risks regurgitation, too small provides inadequate nutrition over time. Resist the urge to overfeed on the theory that a bigger snake is a healthier one: obesity is real and common in captive ball pythons, and a snake that eats every ten days is doing exactly what it should.

Supplements

A whole-prey diet is nutritionally complete, bones and organs included, so ball pythons need no calcium dusting, no D3, and no multivitamin. That is a practice for insect-eating reptiles, and over-supplementing a snake causes mineral imbalance rather than helping. The one thing worth buying instead is a gram scale, because weight is how you actually judge whether the diet is working.

NO DUSTING, NO EXCEPTIONS

If a care sheet tells you to dust a ball python's prey with calcium or a multivitamin, it has been copied from a lizard guide. Whole rodents already carry the calcium in their skeletons, and there is no UVB-dependent D3 requirement to correct for in a species that does not need UVB at all.

Water

A heavy bowl large enough for the snake to soak in, on the cool side, refreshed daily and scrubbed weekly. Soaking supports shedding and hydration and is a behavior the snake will choose for itself when the option exists. A snake that suddenly soaks constantly is telling you something about heat, humidity, or mites, covered on pages 6 and 17.

NEVER FEED

Live prey. A live rodent can bite and seriously injure a snake, sometimes fatally, especially one that isn't hungry enough to strike immediately. The full never-feed list is on page 11.

Prey chart & the never-feed list

Whole prey is both the staple and effectively the only food. There is no treat culture here, and that is fine.

PREY	TIER	NOTES
Frozen-thawed mice, pinky through adult	STAPLE	The whole diet for hatchlings and small juveniles. Size to the snake's widest point.
Frozen-thawed rats, pup through medium	STAPLE	The adult staple. One medium rat replaces several mice and is less work for you and the snake.
African soft-furred rats (ASF)	OCCASIONAL	Useful to restart a stubborn feeder; strongly scented. Some snakes then refuse rats, so use deliberately.
Day-old chicks	OCCASIONAL	A reasonable variety item from a reputable supplier. Not a nutritional requirement.
Quail	RARE	Occasional variety only. More expensive, more mess, no advantage over a correctly sized rat.
Gerbils and hamsters	RARE	Sometimes used as a scenting trick for a refuser. Costly, and not a routine prey item.
Live prey of any kind	NEVER	A live rodent can bite, scratch, and seriously injure a snake that doesn't strike immediately. This is the single most avoidable injury in snake keeping.
Wild-caught rodents	NEVER	Parasite, disease, and rodenticide risk. Buy captive-bred frozen stock from a commercial supplier.
Prey wider than the snake's widest point	NEVER	Causes regurgitation, which is stressful and damaging when it repeats (page 19).
Prey thawed, refused, then refrozen	NEVER	Bacterial risk. Discard anything that has been warmed and turned down.
Insects	NEVER	Not a natural food for this species and not nutritionally adequate for it.
Raw meat, cooked meat, or eggs from the kitchen	NEVER	Not whole prey. Missing the bone, organ, and fur content the diet depends on.
Anything dusted with calcium or vitamins	NEVER	A lizard practice. Over-supplementing a whole-prey feeder causes mineral imbalance (page 10).

BUYING AND STORING

Buy frozen prey in bulk from a commercial rodent supplier and keep it in a sealed bag or box in the freezer, away from human food. Held at a steady 0°F (-18°C) it stays safe indefinitely by FDA guidance, but quality falls the longer it sits, so work through stock rather than letting it stand a year. Label the bag with the size and the date. Never refreeze anything you have thawed. Frozen rodents are also a documented *Salmonella* source for people: keep containers and tongs that touch prey and nothing else, never thaw in a sink you wash dishes in, and wash your hands afterwards.

Thawing, presentation & refusals

Thawing, step by step

- Move the prey from the freezer to the fridge the night before, or thaw from frozen in a sealed bag submerged in cool water.
- Finish in warm, not hot, water in a sealed bag for 20 to 30 minutes, until warm all the way through and about the temperature of live prey, which is what the heat pits look for. Judge it by touch rather than to a number: too hot cooks the prey and can scald the snake.
- Pat it dry. A dripping wet rodent is less appealing and makes a mess of the substrate.
- **Never microwave prey.** It heats unevenly, leaving hot spots that can burn a snake's mouth while the center is still frozen, and it can rupture.

Presentation

Feed in the enclosure, with long tongs. Moving a ball python to a separate feeding tub was standard advice for years, but the added stress is now understood to raise both regurgitation and refusal rates in an already food-shy species. Offer the prey head first with a little movement, and give the snake space rather than standing over the glass. Using tongs every time also builds the association between tongs and food rather than your hand and food.

The seven reasons a ball python stops eating

1. **Shedding.** Appetite drops in the days before a shed, signaled by dull skin and cloudy or blue eyes.
2. **Breeding season, roughly October through March.** Males especially go off food. Completely normal.
3. **Temperature or humidity out of range.** The most common husbandry cause, and the first thing to check.
4. **Not enough cover.** A snake that feels exposed does not eat. Add clutter before you change anything else.
5. **Recent change.** A new home, a rearranged enclosure, or too much handling. Wait about 48 hours after any disturbance before offering again.
6. **Prey presentation.** Prey too cold, too large, or a switch of prey type or color. Try warmer, smaller, or the type the seller used.
7. **Illness.** Last on the list for a reason, and it almost always comes with other signs from page 16.

HOW LONG IS TOO LONG

A healthy adult in good body condition can go three to six months without eating and lose surprisingly little condition; a brooding female can fast four to six months. What turns a fast into a problem is company: real weight loss, lethargy, mucus at the mouth, or wheezing alongside the refusal. A hatchling has far less reserve, so a young snake refusing for more than about two weeks warrants a vet call rather than patience.

DON'T CHASE A REFUSAL

Offering food more often, leaving prey in overnight, or handling the snake to check on it all make refusal more likely. Take the prey out, wait a week, fix anything on the list above, and try again.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Running a heat source without a thermostat, or taping the probe to the mat instead of the surface the snake lies on.
- Treating the small tub as the goal rather than the compromise, then never moving the snake into a real enclosure.
- Guessing at humidity, or trusting an analog dial, instead of reading a digital hygrometer at substrate level.
- Panicking at a refused meal and responding by handling, moving, or offering food more often, all of which make refusal more likely.
- Handling within 48 hours of a meal, then treating the resulting regurgitation as bad luck.
- Leaving the enclosure bare because clutter looks untidy, in an animal whose stress response is driven by feeling exposed.
- Skipping quarantine for a new snake, which is how mites and IBD enter a collection (pages 17 and 18).

Enrichment, by priority

Enrichment comes after correct heat, humidity, and secure hides, never instead of them. Kaufmann and colleagues, in *PLOS ONE*, compared 35 ball pythons in a conventional rack against furnished terrariums and concluded that from a welfare standpoint, racks are not an alternative to a furnished terrarium. In this order:

1. A furnished enclosure

The part with a study behind it. The whole furnished package outperformed the bare one, so treat the enclosure itself as the enrichment rather than something you add items to.

2. Cover across the whole floor

Not just two hides. Cork tubes and flats, leaf litter, and plant cover let the snake be out without being exposed. A cluttered enclosure gets used more, not less.

3. Stable climbing structure

Heavy-bodied and not agile, so the requirement is stability, not height. A branch braced firmly at both ends, or stacked cork, adds usable space to an enclosure that otherwise has only a floor.

4. A basin large enough to soak in

The study's terrariums included a bathing basin, not a drinking cup. It is one of the few genuinely passive enrichment items: you provide it, the animal decides.

5. Scent novelty

Snakes navigate chemically, so a novel scent is closer to a puzzle than a novel object is. A shed skin from another enclosure, or prey dragged across the substrate before offering, costs nothing.

6. Rearrangement, genuinely last

Shifting a branch or adding cork every few weeks is reasonable. Tearing the enclosure down weekly is not, and never at the cost of access to the warm spot.

Sexing, growth & body condition

Telling male from female

Ball pythons show almost no reliable external sex difference before adulthood, which is why even experienced keepers confirm sex by **probing** or **popping** rather than by looking. Both are done by a reptile vet or an experienced breeder, not by a first-time owner: done wrong, either can cause real injury.

Ultrasound is the third route, carries no injury risk, and is documented as reliable for sexing snakes. Read nothing into cloacal spurs: the one measured difference comes from a wild Bahamian boa population and says nothing about the animal in your hands. Adult females do grow larger, and a pet-store guess about a hatchling is exactly that.

Growth reference

Ranges are wide and healthy snakes fall outside them. What matters is the trend: steady gain for a juvenile, a stable weight for an adult. Weigh monthly in grams and log it on page 30.

AGE	LENGTH	WEIGHT
Hatchling, 0 to 6 months	10 to 17 in (25 to 43 cm)	50 to 300 g
Juvenile, 6 to 18 months	18 to 36 in (45 to 90 cm)	300 to 800 g
Sub-adult, 18 months to 3 years	30 to 48 in (75 to 120 cm)	700 to 1,400 g
Adult male, 3 years and up	3 to 3.5 ft (90 to 105 cm)	800 to 1,200 g
Adult female, 3 to 5 years and up	4 to 5 ft (120 to 150 cm)	1,200 to 1,800 g

Adult length is a real disagreement, so both sides are printed: the lengths above are the ReptiFiles and PetMD figures, and VCA gives 5 to 6 ft at maturity. The weights have no veterinary source: read the trend, not the number.

Body condition at a glance

UNDERWEIGHT

A pronounced triangular cross-section with the spine ridged and visible along the back, loose skin folds outside a shed, and a narrow tail base. Rule out parasites, mites, and a cool warm side first (pages 17 and 18), then feed up on the normal schedule rather than by adding meals.

IDEAL

A rounded, slightly loaf-shaped cross-section with the spine felt but not seen, smooth muscle tone along the body, and no fold or crease when the snake coils. Weight stable month to month in an adult, climbing steadily in a juvenile.

OVERWEIGHT

A cross-section closer to round or flattened, skin visible between scales when coiled, and fat rolls or creases along the body. Common in adults fed on a juvenile schedule. Stretch the feeding interval and add floor space and climbing rather than cutting prey size.

WHEN A WEIGHT CHANGE IS A VET VISIT

A juvenile that stops gaining for 4 to 6 weeks. An adult that loses about 10% of its body weight outside a known seasonal fast, or any weight loss that comes with lethargy, a refusal to use the warm side, or abnormal stool. Bring the Owner Log; a trend line tells a vet more than a single reading.

Females, eggs & egg binding

Relevant to every female owner, whether or not a male has ever been in the house.

Females can cycle without a male

From roughly two to three years old, and driven by weight rather than age, a female can develop egg follicles on her own. Most pet females kept alone never lay, and a female that does may produce infertile eggs, sometimes called slugs. Neither outcome is a problem in itself. What matters is recognizing the process, because everything that goes wrong with it goes wrong quietly.

Signs she may be building follicles

- A long refusal of food that starts outside the usual breeding-season window and does not resolve when the setup checks out.
- Noticeable mid-body swelling, and lying belly-up in loose coils, which is a well-known posture in gravid females.
- Seeking the warm side far more than usual, and a pre-lay shed a few weeks before laying.
- Steady weight loss across monthly weigh-ins while she stays otherwise alert. Never squeeze or palpate to check; that is a vet's job.

If she does lay

Give her a large, humid, dark hide she can coil in completely, on the warm side, and leave her alone. A brooding female will wrap the clutch and stay with it, generating heat by shivering thermogenesis, and she may not eat for four to six months while she does. Remove infertile eggs once she leaves them. She will come out of it thin and hungry, so return to the normal feeding schedule promptly and weigh her weekly rather than monthly until the weight comes back.

THIS IS A VET CONVERSATION, NOT A HOME PROJECT

A female cycling repeatedly loses condition every time, and a keeper who did not intend to breed has no reason to let that continue unmanaged. Talk to a reptile vet about her weight, her body condition, and the options, and get her examined rather than waiting to see how the season goes.

Egg binding (dystocia) is an emergency

Eggs she cannot pass. Call a reptile vet the same day if you see any of these:

- Straining or restless digging for more than 24 to 48 hours with nothing produced, or a partial clutch and then she stops and looks exhausted.
- Lethargy, sunken appearance, or a firm lump in the body that does not shift over days.
- Any female past the pre-lay stage who is losing condition rather than laying, or anything protruding from the vent.

Treatment ranges from fluids and supportive care to induced laying or surgery, and the longer it waits the fewer options remain.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A REPTILE VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Wheezing, clicking, or open-mouth breathing at rest · mucus or bubbles at the mouth or nostrils · belly scales discolored, soft, or blistered · pus, pinpoint bleeding, or a sour smell in the mouth · visible mites · a burn over the heat source · anything protruding from the vent · head wobbling, stargazing, or an inability to right itself · repeated regurgitation · refusal to eat alongside real weight loss

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Warm side and cool side surface temperatures, and whether heat runs on a thermostat
- ☐ Current humidity, and where in the enclosure you measured it
- ☐ Date of the last meal, its size, and whether it stayed down
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Last normal bowel movement, and what it looked like
- ☐ Weight trend from the Owner Log, and a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag if you can

Why temperature and humidity come up first

Almost everything in this section traces back to one of the two. Respiratory infection, scale rot, stuck shed, and a large share of feeding refusals are husbandry outcomes before they are illnesses, which is why a reptile vet will ask about your setup before anything else. Having the numbers ready shortens the visit and often changes the diagnosis. The Association of Reptilian and Amphibian Veterinarians keeps a searchable directory of reptile-experienced vets; find one before you need one and write the number on page 23.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Refusing a meal or two in a snake in good body condition, especially in winter or breeding season	Refusal alongside weight loss, lethargy, or any other symptom on this page
Balling up when startled, then relaxing once left alone	Staying balled and hidden constantly, with no interest in moving at night
Cloudy or blue eyes and dull color for a few days before a shed	Shed coming off in fragments, or eye caps still attached afterward
An occasional soak in the water bowl, most often around a shed	Soaking constantly, or rubbing against surfaces persistently

Respiratory infection & scale rot

Respiratory infection (RI)

Cause: temperatures running too low, incorrect humidity in either direction, a dirty enclosure, or ongoing stress. Vets see a seasonal spike each winter as enclosures cool along with the weather outside. **Signs:** wheezing, an audible clicking sound, open-mouth breathing, visible mucus or bubbles around the mouth or nostrils, nasal discharge, lethargy, and in severe cases head tilting. **Diagnosis:** physical exam and listening to the lungs, with the vet asking about your temperature setup directly. **Response:** vet-prescribed antibiotics, not a wait-and-see approach, and correcting the temperature and humidity in parallel or it recurs. **Recovery:** good when caught early; left untreated it can progress to pneumonia and become fatal.

LEARN THIS ONE BY SOUND

RI is the signature ball python illness and the clearest audible signal in this package. If you hear clicking or wheezing, raise the warm side to target, check humidity at substrate level, isolate the snake if you keep others, and call a reptile vet.

Scale rot (infectious dermatitis)

Cause: damp, dirty substrate, excess moisture, or poor enclosure hygiene, which is the exact failure mode of chasing humidity numbers without ventilation. It also follows a water bowl that overflows or sits unchanged. **Signs:** belly scales discolored brown, reddish, or yellow, blisters or sores, scales that feel soft or damaged, and a foul odor. **Diagnosis:** visual exam, with a culture if it is advanced. **Recovery:** move the snake to a clean, dry setup on paper towel immediately and correct humidity; mild cases respond to antiseptic or antibiotic treatment, and affected scales usually resolve over the next one to two shed cycles. Anything spreading or blistering needs a vet.

CONCRETE THRESHOLD

Any belly scale that is discolored and either spreading day to day or blistered is a vet visit this week, not a wait-and-watch. Photograph it against a ruler so the vet can judge progression.

Mouth rot, mites & thermal burns

One arrives on another problem's back, one arrives on a new animal, and one is entirely preventable by a single device.

Mouth rot (infectious stomatitis)

Usually secondary to stress, injury, or ongoing poor husbandry rather than arriving on its own. Watch for pinpoint hemorrhages on the gums, thick excess mucus or pus, cheesy-looking buildup in the mouth, a sour smell, visible swelling, open-mouth breathing, and refusing food. It needs veterinary treatment and does not resolve on its own, and because it usually rides on top of another husbandry problem, the visit should come with an honest account of your setup.

Mites

Ophionyssus natricis, tiny blood-feeding external parasites, almost always introduced on a new snake, on used decor, or from a shop or expo. Look for tiny black or red specks on the scales, clustered around the eyes and heat pits, or floating in the water bowl, along with excessive soaking, rubbing against surfaces, restlessness, and a drop in appetite. A heavy infestation causes anemia and real stress. Treating the snake alone is not enough: the whole enclosure has to be decontaminated at the same time or the infestation simply returns, which usually means stripping substrate completely, switching to paper towel, and repeating on the schedule your vet sets.

Thermal burns

Caused by a heat source running without a thermostat. That is the entire cause. Look for discolored, blistered, or crusted patches on the belly or side, usually over the heat element, sometimes with the snake avoiding the warm side entirely. Burns are wounds and can become infected, so they need a vet. Prevention is page 7: every heat element thermostat-controlled, no hot rocks, and a probe placed where the snake actually contacts the heat.

QUARANTINE IS THE ACTUAL FIX FOR MITES

Quarantine any new snake for **3 to 6 months** before it goes anywhere near an established animal. That is the Merck Veterinary Manual figure for a new reptile, not the 60 to 90 days the hobby usually quotes, and the extra time is what catches a slow problem. A separate room where possible, paper towel substrate, a simple setup you can strip and disinfect, separate tools, and hand-washing between enclosures. Always work with the established animals first and the new one last. Book the first vet visit within two weeks of pickup and bring a fresh fecal sample to it. The same routine is what keeps IBD out of a collection (page 19), and there is a log for it on page 31.

Parasites, regurgitation, obesity & IBD

Less dramatic than the last two pages, and far more common.

Internal parasites

Show up as weight loss and diarrhea despite the snake eating normally, sometimes with visible material in the stool. Wild-caught and imported animals carry them far more often than captive-bred stock. Diagnosis is a fecal test, which is why the first vet visit is worth booking within two weeks of bringing the snake home, with a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag, and why an annual wellness exam with a fecal is the standard recommendation. Treatment is a prescribed antiparasitic plus a full enclosure clean.

Regurgitation

Bringing a meal back up hours to days after eating, most often from handling too soon after a feed, prey that was too large, or a warm side too cool to digest properly. It is hard on the esophagus and repeated episodes cause real damage. After one, leave the snake completely alone for 10 to 14 days, then offer a smaller than usual prey item. Repeated regurgitation is a vet visit, not a feeding adjustment.

Obesity

Real and common in captive ball pythons, and almost always the result of feeding an adult on a juvenile's schedule. Look for the body-condition signs on page 14: a rounded rather than loaf-shaped cross-section, skin visible between the scales when coiled, and creases along the body. The fix is stretching the feeding interval toward every 14 days and adding floor space, cover, and climbing, not cutting prey size while keeping the frequency.

Inclusion Body Disease (IBD)

A serious viral disease of boas and pythons, caused by **reptarenaviruses**. Signs include neurological symptoms such as head wobbling, stargazing, and an inability to right itself, alongside regurgitation and progressive decline. The two families behave differently, which matters during quarantine: a boa can carry the virus for months to years showing little or nothing, while a python usually declines fast once signs start. There is no cure, and it can spread between boids through mites, which is the practical link between this page and the last one. Prevention is the only tool available: source from a reputable captive breeder and quarantine every new animal for 3 to 6 months.

Burns and prolapse

Burns are covered on page 18 and are always a thermostat failure. A prolapse, anything protruding from the vent, is a same-day emergency: keep the tissue moist with clean lukewarm water or saline-dampened gauze, do not attempt to push it back, and get to a reptile vet immediately.

Shedding, refusal & defensive behavior

The shed cycle

A healthy shed comes off in one length. The cycle runs roughly a week to ten days: the skin dulls, the belly may pink up, the eyes go cloudy or blue for a few days, then clear again one to two days before the snake sheds. Appetite drops through most of it and handling stops entirely, because a snake with clouded eyes is functionally blind and startles easily.

THE SHED ROUTINE

From the moment the eyes go blue: raise humidity to 70 to 80%, check the humid hide is genuinely damp and top up the moss, make sure there is a rough surface such as cork for the snake to start the shed against, and leave it alone. Don't handle, don't feed, don't rearrange. After the shed, find the skin and check it for the eye caps.

Stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Caused by humidity running too low, especially through the cycle itself. A bad shed comes off in flakes and patches. Increase humidity, offer a shallow lukewarm soak of 15 to 20 minutes, and gently roll the loosened skin off; never peel it by force. Check the eye caps every time. A retained eye cap is one of the easiest problems to miss because the snake's behavior looks completely normal, and it can cause permanent eye damage if left, so it needs a vet rather than a home attempt with tweezers.

Defensive behavior

Balling up tightly with the head tucked away is a fear response, not aggression, and it is where the species gets its name. Rapid or heavy breathing, hiding the head against your hand, actively trying to move away, or musking, a foul-smelling release from the cloaca, all mean the session is over. Bites are rare and minor, and are typically a feeding response from a snake that smells rodent on your hands rather than a temperament problem. Use tongs at every feeding and wash your hands after handling prey.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

A refused meal is a snake that never struck. A regurgitation is a meal that was eaten and came back up. The first is usually normal and needs patience; the second means something in the setup or the handling schedule is wrong, and it needs to be found before the next feed (page 19).

Reading poop & keeping a ball python hydrated

Stool is the earliest free health check you get. Look at it before you clean it up.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
A firm dark log with a chalky white urate, once every one to two weeks	Normal	Nothing. Snakes defecate on a meal cycle, not a daily one.
Urate yellow, orange, or hard and gritty	Dehydration, and left uncorrected a urate or kidney problem	Check humidity and the water bowl, offer a shallow soak. Vet if it persists past a couple of cycles: the same uric acid chemistry is what causes gout.
Runny, watery, or foul-smelling more than once	Parasites, especially with mucus or blood	Vet with a fresh sample in a sealed bag (page 19).
Fur in a solid undigested clump. Loose fur and bone fragments are normal	Warm side too cool to digest properly	Re-measure the warm side surface and check the thermostat probe (page 7).
Black, tarry, or with red streaks	Possible blood in the digestive tract	Vet the same day.
Nothing at all, but the snake is eating and gaining	Normal between meals, or a slow cycle	Watch. Log the date of the last one so you know the interval.
Nothing for 3 or more feeding cycles, or straining with nothing produced	Possible impaction or obstruction	Vet promptly, and mention substrate type and prey size.

Hydration

Most of a ball python's water comes from drinking and from ambient humidity rather than from food, so the water bowl is not decoration. Beyond keeping it full:

- Use a bowl heavy enough not to tip and large enough for the snake to fully enter, on the cool side. Refresh daily and scrub weekly, since a soaking snake will also defecate in it.
- Keep humidity in the 55 to 65% band as the baseline hydration tool. A snake that is chronically dry sheds badly long before it looks dehydrated.
- A shallow lukewarm soak of 15 to 20 minutes helps a stuck shed or a dehydrated snake. Chest-deep at most, never unsupervised, and never hot water.

SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

Wrinkled or loose skin outside a shed, sunken eyes, thick or stringy saliva, yellow or hard urates, sheds coming off in pieces, and lethargy. Mild cases respond to corrected humidity and a soak; a snake that is sunken and lethargic needs a vet for fluids.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm) enclosure, secure and locking, front-opening
- ☐ PVC preferred; glass covered on three sides
- ☐ Heat source sized to the enclosure
- ☐ Thermostat, one per heat source, no exceptions
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer, plus an infrared gun
- ☐ Cypress mulch or coconut coir, 3 to 4 in (7.5 to 10 cm) deep
- ☐ Two snug hides, warm side and cool side
- ☐ Humid hide with sphagnum moss
- ☐ Heavy water bowl large enough to soak in
- ☐ Cork, a braced branch, and leaf litter for cover
- ☐ Timer for a 12 hour light, 12 hour dark cycle
- ☐ Frozen-thawed rodent supply, feeding tongs, and a gram scale

Temperature & climate targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Warm side surface	88 to 92	31 to 33
Air ceiling, anywhere	never above 95	never above 35
Cool side	75 to 80	24 to 27
Nighttime low	72 to 75	22 to 24
Humidity	55 to 65% baseline, 70 to 80% through a shed	
Light cycle	12 hours light, 12 hours dark, on a timer	

Before your ball python comes home

- ☐ Enclosure running for 24 to 48 hours with stable readings
- ☐ Thermostat probe placed where the snake will lie, not on the mat
- ☐ Lid latch tested, and frozen prey in the freezer at the seller's size
- ☐ Reptile vet found and first appointment booked (page 25)

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

Wheezing, clicking, or open-mouth breathing · bubbles or mucus at the mouth or nose · belly scales blistering or discoloration spreading · pus or a sour smell in the mouth · anything protruding from the vent · visible mites · a burn over the heat source · head wobbling or stargazing · repeated regurgitation · refusal to eat alongside real weight loss

READING	°F	°C
Warm side surface	88 to 92	31 to 33
Air ceiling, anywhere	never above 95	never above 35
Cool side	75 to 80	24 to 27
Nighttime low	72 to 75	22 to 24
Humidity, baseline / shed	55 to 65% / 70 to 80%	
Feeding interval, adult	Every 10 to 14 days; wait 48 to 72 hours after a meal to handle	

Your numbers

Reptile vet _____

Thermostat set point _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

Last substrate change _____

Snake's name and hatch date _____

Last vet visit _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Warm and cool side surface temperatures, current humidity, whether heat runs on a thermostat, the date and size of the last meal and whether it stayed down, the date and quality of the last shed, and the weight trend from the Owner Log on page 30.

Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium equipment.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
4×2×2 ft enclosure (glass at the low end, PVC at the high end)	\$100 to \$450
Heat source: under-tank heater, heat tape, ceramic emitter, or radiant panel	\$30 to \$80
Thermostat (on/off or pulse; dimming if you run halogen)	\$25 to \$100
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$15 to \$25
Infrared thermometer gun	\$15 to \$30
Substrate, first fill of cypress mulch or coconut coir	\$10 to \$40
Two snug hides plus a humid hide	\$15 to \$35
Soakable water bowl	\$15 to \$25
Cork bark, branches, and leaf litter	\$20 to \$40
Feeding tongs, spray bottle, and a gram scale	\$10 to \$20
Equipment subtotal	\$255 to \$845
First vet exam with a fecal test	\$50 to \$150
All-in before the ball python arrives	\$305 to \$995

Optional low-level UVB and a photoperiod LED add \$20 to \$70. The snake itself is \$40 to \$100 for a normal and \$50 to \$150 for a common single-gene morph; designer morphs run far higher and are no easier to keep.

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Frozen-thawed rodents	\$8 to \$17
Substrate replacement, every 4 to 8 weeks	\$3 to \$10
Electricity, heat running continuously	\$2 to \$7
Annual wellness exam, averaged	\$4 to \$13
Monthly ongoing	\$17 to \$47

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$500 or more, with imaging or surgery higher. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The thermostat and the enclosure. The thermostat is the difference between a heat source and a burn, and enclosure size and material drive the humidity stability that most of Section 03 depends on. Save on decor before you save on either.

First 30 days checklist

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the ball python in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ Confirm warm side, cool side, and humidity with real instruments, then leave the snake alone
- ☐ Fill in the numbers on page 23 and the equipment dates on page 31

Week 1

- ☐ Hands off entirely: fresh water and spot-cleaning only, no handling and no rearranging
- ☐ Book a wellness visit with a reptile vet for within the first two weeks, and take a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag
- ☐ Offer the first meal at the end of the week, at the seller's prey type and size. A refusal now is ordinary

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short handling sessions only once the snake has eaten successfully at least once, 15 minutes at most
- ☐ Never handle within 48 to 72 hours of a meal, and not at all once the eyes go blue
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 30 with a weekly weigh-in

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. Steady gain is the goal for a juvenile, stable weight for an adult
- ☐ Check the humid hide is still genuinely damp and top up the moss
- ☐ Introduce the first enrichment items from page 32

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and act on the fecal result
- ☐ Watch the first shed closely and log its quality, including whether the eye caps came away
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or humidity
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 32, and fill in the pet-sitter sheet on page 29 before you need it

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Wheezing, clicking, open-mouth breathing, bubbles at the mouth	Respiratory infection	Reptile vet promptly; raise the warm side (page 17)
Belly scales discolored, soft, or blistered	Scale rot	Clean dry setup on paper towel now; vet if spreading (page 17)
Pus, sour smell, or pinpoint bleeding in the mouth	Mouth rot	Vet; does not self-resolve (page 18)
Black or red specks on scales or in the water bowl	Mites	Vet plus full enclosure decontamination (page 18)
Burn or blister over the heat source	Unregulated heat	Vet; fit a thermostat before anything else (pages 7 and 17)
Weight loss and diarrhea despite eating	Internal parasites	Vet with a fresh stool sample (page 19)
Meal brought back up a day or two later	Regurgitation	Rest 10 to 14 days, then smaller prey; check the warm side (page 19)
Head wobbling, stargazing, unable to right itself	Neurological, possibly IBD	Vet immediately; isolate from other snakes (page 19)
Shed coming off in patches, or eye caps retained	Humidity too low	Raise to 70 to 80%, soak, then vet for eye caps (page 20)
Refusing food, otherwise normal and holding weight	Season, shed, or husbandry	Work the seven-reason list, then wait (page 12)
Refusing food with weight loss or lethargy	Several possible causes	Vet, bring the Owner Log (page 30)
Soaking constantly, rubbing against surfaces	Mites, or too dry or too warm	Check for mites first, then temps (pages 6 and 17)
Out and roaming persistently, never settling	Too little cover, or too warm	Add clutter, verify temps (pages 5 and 6)
Anything protruding from the vent	Prolapse	Keep moist, do not push back, vet same day (page 19)
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet, bring the Owner Log (page 30)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Check warm side, cool side, and humidity readings
- ☐ Refresh the water bowl and spot-clean any waste
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes, mouth, belly scales, breathing, posture

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it on page 30
- ☐ Feed per the age interval on page 10, and log the prey size and outcome
- ☐ Scrub the water bowl rather than topping it up, and check the humid hide is damp

Monthly

- ☐ Verify the thermostat holds its set point and the probe hasn't shifted
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings

Every 3 months

- ☐ Full substrate change and enclosure deep clean; check hides still fit snugly as the snake grows

Seasonal

- ☐ Re-check the room in winter. The cold-weather drop is when respiratory infections spike
- ☐ Expect reduced appetite through breeding season, roughly October to March, and check that dry indoor heating hasn't pulled humidity below range

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam with a fecal test
- ☐ Reassess the enclosure against the snake's current length, and replace worn hides and branches

Power outages, travel & transport

A healthy adult tolerates one cool night without harm. The risk is days without heat, and feeding a snake that can't digest.

When the power goes out

Do

- Keep the snake in its normal night range, 72 to 75°F (22 to 24°C). Sustained below that for more than a day or two is the classic winter trigger for respiratory infection.
- Drape thick towels or a blanket over the enclosure, leaving a vent gap.
- Move the enclosure, or the snake in a ventilated tub, to the warmest room.
- Use hand warmers or a hot-water bottle wrapped in a towel, placed beside the snake, never touching it.
- Stop feeding. Water only until the warm side is back to target.
- Past two days below 72°F (22°C), board it with a vet, a friend with power, or a reptile shop.

Don't

- Don't use candles, gas stoves, or open flame anywhere near the enclosure.
- Don't put a heat pack in direct contact with the snake; it can't move away fast enough and will burn.
- Don't feed "to keep its strength up." A meal in a cold gut rots and is regurgitated at best.
- Don't warm a cold snake in hot water; lukewarm only, and only once it's alert.

OUTAGE KIT

Hand warmers, a hot-water bottle, two thick towels, a battery thermometer, a ventilated locking tub, and the vet numbers from page 23.

Leaving town

TRIP LENGTH	ADULT	JUVENILE (UNDER 18 MONTHS)
1 to 2 nights	Fine alone. Thermostat on, timer set, fresh water before you go. Feed before you leave or after you're back, not the morning of.	Fine alone if it fed recently. Fresh water and a temperature check before you go.
3 to 7 nights	A sitter every 2 to 3 days for water, a temperature check, and a look at the snake. No feeding needed on most schedules.	A sitter every 2 days, with one feeding if the interval falls in the trip. Leave written instructions (page 29).
Over a week	A daily or every-other-day sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a reptile-experienced vet or specialist shop.	

Transport and vet trips

- A ventilated, locking plastic tub with a towel or crumpled paper to grip and hide in, inside a dark insulated bag or box. No loose substrate, no water dish sloshing.
- Warm the car before loading in cold weather, and add a wrapped hand warmer beside the tub for trips over 30 minutes below 65°F (18°C).
- Don't travel within 48 hours of a meal. Never leave the ball python in a parked car, hot or cold, even briefly.
- Moving house: set the enclosure up and running at the new place before the snake goes in, exactly as on day one, and expect a refused meal or two afterward.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Snake's name _____

Age and normal weight _____

My phone _____

Reptile vet _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- ☐ Check the thermometers. Warm end should read 88 to 92°F (31 to 33°C), cool end 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), humidity 55 to 65%.
- ☐ Rinse and refill the water bowl. It's normal for the snake to be sitting in it.
- ☐ Look for the snake and check it's breathing quietly with its mouth closed. It will usually be inside a hide or under the substrate, which is normal.
- ☐ Scoop any waste with a paper towel. Normal is a dark log with a chalky white end, roughly every one to two weeks.
- ☐ Feeding, only if I've marked a date: _____ . Prey is in the freezer, size _____ . Thaw per the note on the fridge, offer with the tongs, and remove it if untouched after 20 minutes.
- ☐ Wash your hands before and after. Don't rinse anything in the kitchen sink.

Please don't

- Take the snake out of the enclosure or handle it, unless we agreed on it. It is fine on its own for the whole trip.
- Change any dial, timer, or thermostat setting, or move the lights.
- Feed anything not on this sheet, and never a live rodent.
- Leave the lid unlatched, even for a moment. This snake will find any gap.

CALL ME IF

The warm end reads below 80°F (27°C) or above 95°F (35°C) · the snake is breathing with its mouth open, wheezing, or clicking · there are bubbles or mucus at its mouth or nose · there are tiny black or red specks on the snake or floating in the water bowl · its belly scales look discolored, wet-looking, or blistered · anything is protruding from the tail end · it has brought a meal back up · you can't find it at all · anything else that looks wrong. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

In a species that normally refuses meals, the weight trend is the only thing that tells you whether a fast is routine or a symptom. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a weight change before anything else is visible. Sixteen rows is four months; that's long enough to see a real trend.

Equipment, quarantine & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
Thermostat (verify set point monthly)			
Heat source			
Substrate, full change every 4 to 8 weeks			
Thermometer and hygrometer batteries			
Frozen prey stock, check date and quality			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Start with whichever month you're in.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Verify thermostat and probe	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Full substrate change	☐			☐			☐			☐		
Vet exam	☐											☐

Quarantine log (any new snake, 3 to 6 months)

DATE IN	DATE OUT	MITE CHECKS, SHEDS, FEEDS, AND ANYTHING NOTICED

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Cover across the whole floor, not only inside the two hides
- ☐ Stable climbing structure braced at both ends, low enough that a fall isn't one
- ☐ Water basin large enough for the snake to fully enter

Monthly review

- ☐ Add or reposition one piece of cover, without blocking access to the warm spot
- ☐ Offer a scent novelty: a shed skin from another enclosure, or prey dragged across the substrate first
- ☐ Check the snake is using more of the floor than last month, not less

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't treat handling as enrichment, especially around a shed cycle. Don't stack decor so densely that the snake can't reach the warm spot; thermal access outranks everything here. And don't read a still, hidden snake in a bare enclosure as a calm one, because that is exactly the pattern the rack comparison on page 13 produced.

Glossary

Cloacal spurs	The small claw-like remnants of hind limbs either side of the vent. Larger in adult males, but not a reliable way to sex a snake.
Dysecdysis	Incomplete or stuck shedding. In this species almost always a humidity problem rather than a skin one.
Dystocia	Egg binding: eggs a female cannot pass. A same-day emergency (page 15).
Eye cap (spectacle)	The clear scale covering the eye, shed with the rest of the skin. A retained cap is easy to miss and needs a vet.
Frozen-thawed (F/T)	Prey frozen after humane dispatch and thawed before feeding. The standard and far safer alternative to live prey.
Gravid	Carrying eggs. Used for reptiles in place of pregnant.
Heat pits	Openings along the upper lip that detect the body warmth of prey, letting a ball python strike accurately in the dark.
Humid hide	A closed hide packed with damp sphagnum moss, giving the snake a high-humidity pocket it can choose to use.
IBD	Inclusion Body Disease: a serious viral disease of boas and pythons with no cure. Prevention is quarantine and mite control.
Morph	A selectively bred color or pattern variant. A normal is not a lesser snake, and morphs are no easier or harder to keep.
Musking	A foul-smelling release from the cloaca. A clear signal that the snake feels threatened and the session is over.
Popping and probing	The two methods of sexing a snake. Both are done by a vet or an experienced breeder; done wrong, either can injure the animal.
Regurgitation	Bringing a meal back up after swallowing, most often from handling too soon, oversized prey, or insufficient warmth.
Scale rot	Infectious dermatitis of the belly scales, driven by damp or dirty substrate.
Slug	An infertile egg. A female kept alone can produce these without ever meeting a male.
Stargazing	Holding the head tilted up and back, unable to right itself. A neurological sign and an immediate vet visit.
Stomatitis	Mouth rot: bacterial infection of the mouth, usually secondary to stress or poor husbandry.
Thermostat	The device that regulates a heat source to a set temperature. Not a dimmer, not a timer, and not optional.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary sources

- Merck Veterinary Manual: management and husbandry of reptiles, and its parasitic and viral disease pages. Thermostat control and hot rocks, the 3 to 6 month quarantine, mite-borne transmission, and reptarenavirus in boas against pythons.
- VCA Animal Hospitals: Snakes, Housing; Snakes, Owning; and Veterinary Care, New Reptile Visit. Heat-source clearance, night temperature, adult length at maturity, and the first exam within two weeks with a fecal sample.
- PetMD, Ball Python Care Sheet, for husbandry, feeding and common conditions.
- Association of Reptilian and Amphibian Veterinarians, for the vet directory on pages 15 and 22.

Scientific sources

- Kaufmann et al. Animal-appropriate housing of ball pythons (*Python regius*). *PLOS ONE*. Page 13.
- Hutchings. Recent scientific insight into the spatial needs of captive snakes. *International Journal of Zoology*, 2025.
- Burghardt. Environmental enrichment and cognitive complexity in reptiles and amphibians. *Applied Animal Behaviour Science*, 2013.
- Vetere, Capasso & Di Ianni. Sex determination in reptiles: a review. *Animals*, 2025. Ultrasound, and the injury risk in popping.
- Hoefer, Robinson & Pinou. Sexual dimorphism in the pelvic spurs of the Bahamian boa. *Herpetology Notes*, 2021. Page 14.
- Falk, Snow & Reed. A validation of 11 body-condition indices in a giant snake species. *PLOS ONE*, 2017. Why weight beats length.

Public health and food safety

- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: reptiles and amphibians, and frozen feeder rodents. Pages 9 and 11.
- Center for Food Security and Public Health, Iowa State University: Reptile- and Amphibian-Associated Salmonellosis.
- US Food and Drug Administration, on frozen storage at a steady 0°F.

Husbandry references

- ReptiFiles ball python care guide, and the Zen Habitats care sheet it provides.
- Animal Diversity Web (University of Michigan), *Python regius*, for range and wild size.
- Beastly Facts guides, current at publication: the ball python tank setup, feeding, health, handling, cost and enrichment guides, plus the cross-species reptile heating and thermostats, quarantine, salmonella and hygiene, stool and urates, shedding, snake sexing, and emergency plan guides.

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed, and when, so an older printout can be placed.

WHERE THE SOURCES DISAGREE

Adult length on page 14: the care sheets give an adult female 4 to 5 ft, VCA gives 5 to 6 ft, and both are printed. The growth weights there have no veterinary source. Prey warmth on page 12 is given by touch rather than as a number, because no veterinary source states one.

Version history

VERSION	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
2.2 · Sep 2026	t3	Cross-checked against the September 2026 cross-species reptile articles. Quarantine raised from 60 to 90 days to the Merck figure of 3 to 6 months on pages 18, 19 and 31. Cloacal spurs reframed and ultrasound added on page 14, where adult length now prints the VCA figure beside the care-sheet one. The prey core-temperature figure on page 12 removed, since no veterinary source gives one. IBD attributed to reptarenaviruses, with the boa and python difference. Freezer storage reframed to the FDA figure, with the CDC prey-handling rules added. Salmonella callout rewritten. Urate and stool rows corrected. Soak time aligned to 15 to 20 minutes. Sources and version history split onto their own pages.
2.1 · Sep 2026	t3	Baseline humidity corrected from 55 to 70% down to 55 to 65%, which is the figure the ReptiFiles and Zen Habitats care sheets actually give. The 70 to 80% shed range is unchanged.
2.0 · Sep 2026	t3	34 pages. Substrate and handling split onto their own pages, restoring the full handling technique, session frequency, and settling-in guidance that the one-page version had to compress. Adds a cleaning routine and a hide-fit note.
1.0 · Sep 2026	t3	First edition. 33 pages on the t3 package template. Both units throughout, a probe-placement diagram, a full prey chart, and the peer-reviewed housing research on page 13.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources on page 34 and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a reptile veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Free companion guides, updated as guidance changes, are at beastlyfacts.com.

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